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Interview plan and script

Astral customer discovery
Draft for review · October 2026

Interview plan and script



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The plan

Interview plan

Proposed 60-minute remote sessions. Interview plus a walkthrough of a recent piece of work. We ask about the last real time, not about features. Then we follow that episode through its tools, decisions, and handoffs.

ONE ROUND

12 participants, 3 from each of four user groups, across several organisations. Understand real, recent episodes of work before showing any proposed screens.

3 interview days in week 2, 4 sessions a day

OUTPUT

Episode-level evidence, journey fragments, candidate behaviours, and any gaps to name in the report.

STAGE 2 · INTERVIEW RECRUITMENT

Screen and book 12 people who do the work, 3 from each of four user groups, into the interview days in week 2.

Week 1

STAGE 3 · INTERVIEW PREP

Finish the interview script, set up and test recording and transcription, and brief the notetaker.

Days 2 to 5 of week 1, alongside recruitment

OBJECTIVES IT SERVES

- 1. **Understand** how customers do their energy-data work today, from trigger to finished outcome, including spreadsheets, email, and other tools.
- 2. **Identify** recurring behavioural patterns that need different design priorities or trade-offs.
- 3. **Understand** what people check before they trust and share a figure or a report.
- 4. **Identify** who does, approves, and receives the work, and where handoffs and waiting happen.
- 5. **Determine** where problems come from the service, process, or data rather than the interface.

NOT IN THESE SESSIONS

Prototype screens. A prototype steers the conversation towards its own features. Testing design changes is a possible follow-on study.

PRIMARY RESEARCH QUESTION

How do IMSERV customers do their energy-data work today, and which differences in that work should change how Astral is designed and prioritised?

Who we interview

Twelve people, three from each of four user groups. Each group comes from more than one customer organisation where we can.

User group	What they need to do	Interviews
Energy managers	Understand use, spikes, and which sites waste energy	3
Finance users	Find where spend is highest, why, and where to cut	3
Brokers / TPIs	Act for one or more customers, with reports, invoices, and energy data	3
Data and asset users	Get reliable data into another process, or check meter faults are repaired	3

THE PEOPLE WHO DO THE WORK

Separate the buyer, administrator, practitioner, approver, and recipient of outputs. A senior contact may not do the everyday work.

RECRUITMENT · STAGE 2

Clive and the access coordinator suggest people. A short screener confirms they do the work. Criteria for each group are in the proposal.

EXCLUSIONS

IMSERV staff standing in for customers. People who designed the flows being discussed.

The groups are a starting point for recruitment. They are not the archetypes. Archetypes come from what people do.

Balance within each group

Within each group of three, we aim for contrasts likely to change a design decision. We will not fill every combination.

Dimension	Examples
Activities actually performed	Investigating data, reconciling figures, reporting, managing access, resolving service issues
Frequency and experience	Regular, occasional, newly onboarded, experienced
Scale and complexity	One site or a portfolio. Simple or several organisational relationships
Working relationships	Direct customer work, or delegated and intermediary work such as Broker / TPI
Service experience	Works well, repeated difficulty, gave up, or relies on someone else
Tools and channels	Portal, spreadsheet, email, API, telephone, and combinations
Access needs	Assistive technology, magnification, digital confidence, other support needs

Getting ready

Stage 3 runs alongside recruitment in week 1. Everything here is in place before the first interview day.

Before the interview days

- Finish the plan and script. Agree it with Clive and the manager
- Consent wording approved by the privacy owner
- Recording and transcription set up in the approved tool, and tested end to end
- A restricted storage folder for recordings, transcripts, and notes
- Invites sent with the joining link, what to expect, and the consent information
- Notetaker briefed, with a note template for each session
- One practice session with a colleague to check timings

A sample interview day

Time	What happens
09:30 to 10:30	Session 1
10:30 to 11:00	Write up notes
11:00 to 12:00	Session 2
12:00 to 13:30	Lunch. Write up notes
13:30 to 14:30	Session 3
14:30 to 15:00	Write up notes
15:00 to 16:00	Session 4
After the last session	Write up notes. Note early themes for the BA team

Four a day over three days covers all 12. Six is the most on a catch-up day. Every session needs a moderator and a notetaker.

Running order

Proposed timings for a 60-minute session, with 5 minutes spare. Adjust in the first sessions.



Part	Minutes	Aim	Questions	Objectives
A. Welcome and consent	5	Put the participant at ease and confirm consent before anything is recorded.	—	
B. Your work	5	Understand the person's role and how they reach IMSERV data, so the episode that follows makes sense.	I1, I2, I3	OBJ 1 OBJ 4
C. The last real time	20	Follow one real, recent episode from what started it to how it finished. Ask about the last real time, not about features.	I4, I5, I6, I7, I8, I9, I10	OBJ 1 OBJ 3 OBJ 4 OBJ 5
D. Walk us through it	20	See the tools, checks, workarounds, and handoffs, not just hear about them.	I11, I12, I13, I14	OBJ 1 OBJ 3 OBJ 4 OBJ 5
E. Wrap up	5	Place the episode against the person's usual work, and close.	I15, I16	OBJ 2

Do

- Ask about the last real time, not about features.
- Follow that episode through its tools, decisions, and handoffs.
- Ask what happened, then why.
- Use neutral probes: “Tell me more”, “What happened next?”
- Note observation and interpretation separately.

Don't

- Show prototype screens. A prototype steers the conversation towards its own features.
- Ask which hat or persona someone is, or what features they would like.
- Suggest answers or finish people's sentences.
- Explain or defend how the portal should work.
- Keep unredacted customer documents.

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The script

PART A · 5 MINUTES

Welcome and consent

Put the participant at ease and confirm consent before anything is recorded.



SAY

“Thank you for making the time. I'm [name], from the UX team at IMSERV. [Name] is here to take notes.”

“We're learning how you do your energy-data work today, so we can design Astral around how people really work.”

“There are no right or wrong answers. We're not testing you, and we won't show you any new designs today.”

“[Approved consent wording: recording, storage, who sees it, anonymised quotes, and stopping at any time.]”

“Are you happy to go ahead? Is there anything you'd like to ask before we start?”

Confirm consent to record and, separately, consent to anonymised quotation.
Start recording only after consent is confirmed.

PART B · 5 MINUTES

Your work

Understand the person's role and how they reach IMSERV data, so the episode that follows makes sense.



I1	Tell me about your role. What are you responsible for? Probe: Who do you work with most?	OBJ 4
I2	What do you use IMSERV data for? Probe: What else? · How often does that come up?	OBJ 1
I3	How do you get to that data today? Probe: Do you log in yourself, or does someone send it to you?	OBJ 1

PART C · 20 MINUTES

The last real time

Follow one real, recent episode from what started it to how it finished. Ask about the last real time, not about features.



OPEN WITH

"Tell me about the last time you needed to investigate a figure that did not look right. What triggered it, and what happened next?"

OR, FOR THE AGREED SCENARIO

"Tell me about the last time you needed to get access to IMSERV data and reach something you could use."

"Tell me about the last time you prepared and shared evidence for a business decision."

Use the opener for the priority scenario agreed in stage 1. The starting scenarios are to confirm, not agreed.

I4 TRIGGER AND OUTCOME — OBJ 1

What started the work? What had to be achieved?

Probe: Who asked for it? · By when?

I5 ACTUAL PROCESS — OBJ 1

What did you do first? What happened after that?

Probe: And then? · Why that way?

I6 EVIDENCE AND TRUST — OBJ 3

What did you check before relying on the result?

Probe: How did you know it was right? · What would have made you doubt it?

I7 TOOLS AND WORKAROUNDS — OBJ 1 OBJ 5

What left the portal? What happened in a spreadsheet or email?

Probe: Why there?

PART C · 20 MINUTES

The last real time

Follow one real, recent episode from what started it to how it finished. Ask about the last real time, not about features.



I8 COLLABORATION — OBJ 4

Who contributed, approved, or acted? What information did they need?

Probe: Did you wait for anyone? · How long?

I9 DIFFICULTY AND CONSEQUENCES — OBJ 5

Where did it slow down? What happened when it went wrong?

Probe: What caused that? · Who could fix it?

I10 COMPLETION — OBJ 1

How did you know it was finished, not just sent to someone else?

PART D · 20 MINUTES

Walk us through it

See the tools, checks, workarounds, and handoffs, not just hear about them.

A | B | C | D | E | +5

SAY

"If it's appropriate and you're allowed to, could you show me the report, spreadsheet, email, or output from that piece of work? Please hide anything you can't share."

If nothing can be shown, ask them to describe it step by step. Do not push.

Customer documents are redacted or not kept, as agreed.

Watch for.

- Tools and windows opened
- Checks made, and in what order
- Copying, re-keying, or reformatting
- Handoffs and waiting
- Where things went wrong, and what the person did

I11	Talk me through how you got to this.	OBJ 1
I12	Show me what you checked before you shared it.	OBJ 3
I13	Which parts came from the portal, and which did you add or change somewhere else?	OBJ 1 OBJ 5
I14	Who did this go to next, and what did they do with it?	OBJ 4

PART E · 5 MINUTES

Wrap up

Place the episode against the person's usual work, and close.



I15 Is that a typical piece of work for you? How often does something like it happen? OBJ 2

Probe: What is different when it goes well?

I16 Is there anything about this work we should have asked, but didn't?

SAY

"Thank you, that's really helpful. We'll put what you've told us together with other conversations. Nothing is shared with your name on it."

"If a question comes up later, would you be happy for us to get in touch for a short follow-up?"

Questions to objectives

Every question serves an objective. Objective 6 is answered by the survey, not by these sessions.

Objective	Research question	Questions that answer it
1. Understand	What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?	**I2**, **I3**, **I4**, **I5**, **I7**, **I10**, **I11**, **I13**
2. Identify	Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?	**I15**
3. Understand	What do people check before relying on a figure?	**I6**, **I12**
4. Identify	Who contributes, approves, or acts?	**I1**, **I8**, **I14**
5. Determine	Where does it slow down, and why?	**I7**, **I9**, **I13**

After the session

Write up notes the same day. Full analysis runs in week 3, together with the survey results.

ANALYSIS

- Code against objectives, then open coding.
- Separate observation from interpretation.
- Look for contradictions and outliers.
- Participants are P01, P02 in analysis.

SHARING

- Early themes from the interview days are shared with the BA team, marked provisional
- Stories link back to the need and evidence behind them
- The BA team (Claire and others) can add open story questions to the script before the interview days

When to add interviews

CONTEXTS

Important contexts are still unexplored.

DIFFERENCES

New behavioural differences keep appearing.

CONTRADICTIONS

Consequential contradictions are unresolved.

If these appear, use the reserves. If gaps remain, name them in the report.

On sample size

GOV.UK suggests about 4 to 8 participants per qualitative round. A systematic review found saturation often within 9 to 17 interviews, in fairly similar groups with narrow aims (Hennink and Kaiser, 2022).

What that does not show

It does **not** show 12 interviews are enough for IMSERV's varied, multi-role audience. Three people per group is a starting proposal, not a promise of coverage. A rare, high-impact need is not dropped because it appeared once.

Neutral draft. No consent wording is sent until it is approved. Legal review before it reaches a participant.

Consent, privacy and data

Agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session.

Every session

- Informed consent for every participant before the session
- Recording, transcription, storage, retention, and any AI processing agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session
- Approved storage with restricted access. Raw recordings and transcripts stay restricted
- Customer documents shown in walkthroughs are redacted or not kept, as agreed
- Participants are P01, P02 in analysis. Removing names alone may not anonymise a distinctive business account
- Quotes in shared outputs only with consent for anonymised quotation
- No consent wording is sent until it is approved. The current wording is a neutral draft

How AI is used

Copilot can help organise approved material, suggest candidate patterns, and keep evidence links up to date. Only within what the privacy owner approves.

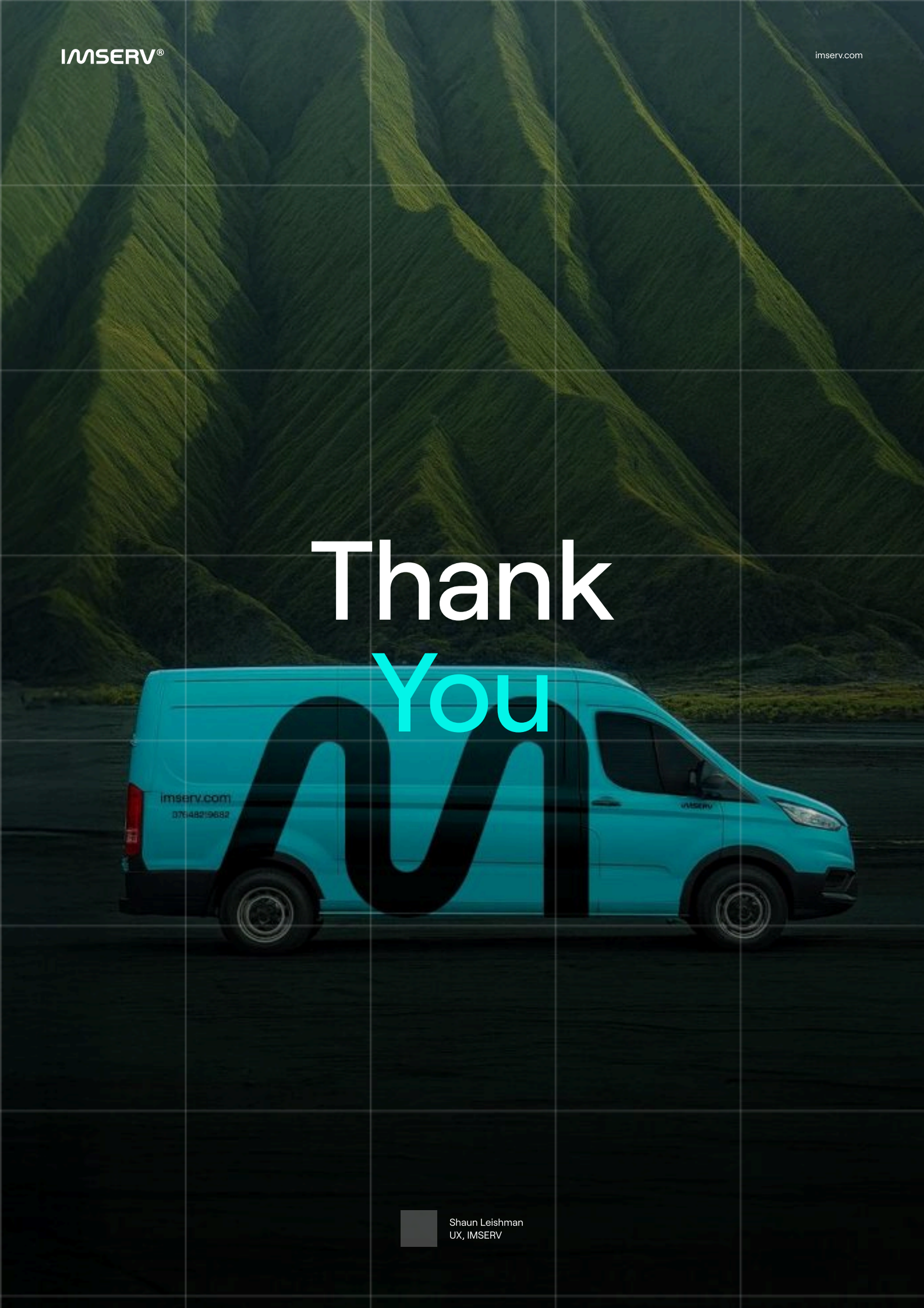
It will **not** invent quotes, build archetypes from job titles, or treat simulated customers as evidence.

Risks and limits

What could weaken the evidence, and what we do about it.

Risk	Effect	Mitigation
Four weeks leaves no slack	One late approval or several no-shows moves the whole plan	Start only when everything in Before week 1 is done. Keep day 5 of week 2 for catch-ups. Agree with the manager what can slip first
Introductions only reach senior contacts	We hear about the work, not from the people doing it	Ask for practitioners by the activity they do. Track who does what in the screener
Participants come from one or two organisations	Shared local process looks like a pattern	Track organisation coverage. Recruit across several
Four interviews a day, three days running, tires the researchers	Later sessions get thinner probing and notes	One moderator and one notetaker. Gaps between sessions. Write up notes the same day
Prototype screens steer discovery	We confirm our own design	No screens in this study. Test design changes in a follow-on study
Twelve interviews leave gaps in a multi-role audience	Three per group shows differences between groups, not everything about each group	Recruit across several organisations. Name the gaps in the report, and propose extra sessions where they matter
Archetypes are expected before evidence exists	A persona deck without support	Agree upfront that archetypes emerge from the interviews and survey

Thank You



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